

A note to begin

TENDS is a small-dog-only food and care brand — plant-based, oven-baked, designed from the small body up rather than scaled down from a larger one. We're launching in Mumbai.

Rather than a single release, we've put together four pieces. The story sits at a few angles, and you'll know better than we do which one fits your readers.

It starts with the founder's note — how TENDS came about, and why it's built the way it is. Then three cuts on the same story, each written for a different reader.

A Clinical Cut — the nutritional case for designing food around the small-dog envelope rather than shrinking a larger formula to fit. For clinical and veterinary readers.

A Story Cut — the human side. Why a founder with no dog of his own built a brand for the biggest urban-dog population there is.

A Sustainability Cut — how a smaller footprint fell out of the design rather than being added on top of it.

None of them repeats the others. Read the one that fits, or read all four.

I'm glad to talk — on the record, on background, whatever's useful. There's more ready whenever you need it: photography, pack shots, founder portraits and further detail, all of it on this page.

Thank you for the time.

— Chan Patel
Founder, TENDS



Chan Patel, Founder

How TENDS Came About

Twenty years inside. A decade since looking from outside.

Long enough in the pet food industry to see how products are made, what owners are told, what the science supports, and where each comes up short. Long enough also to start noticing what heritage and home each had to bring. Not in the abstract. Specifically, in food.

Hill's Pet Nutrition, the pet food division of Colgate-Palmolive, 1996 to 2016. Twenty years across the global pet category in senior commercial leadership roles. General Manager for the Middle East and Africa region — Greece, Turkey, South Africa, Israel, Cyprus, Malta, the UAE. Then a global role as Director of Indirect Trade, building channel architecture across Russia, South Africa, CEEMA, LATAM, and Asia. From 2014, General Manager for the Far East — Singapore, Thailand, Taiwan, South Korea, Malaysia, Indonesia, Hong Kong, the Philippines, with India in the developing-market remit.

The work spanned both wellness and therapeutic tiers — Science Diet and Prescription Diet — across cat and dog, vet and retailer, every stage of category development. Selected for the Tuck School of Business Global Leadership 2030 cohort during the period.

In 2019 I founded PetThinQ — analytics and insights work, from outside the industry now rather than inside it. Reading pet parents through forum conversations, product reviews and feedback at scale, thousands of product analyses, mapping where the category was answering and where it wasn't.

Hill's gave me inside looking out. PetThinQ gave me outside looking in.

What both had been pointing at was a structural answer the category was still trying to give at the marketing layer. Small dogs are a different envelope, and food designed for a larger envelope and shrunk to fit is the category's default answer to a question it hasn't quite asked properly.

That observation made TENDS the thing to build.

What heritage and home had been showing me, more quietly, was how to build it.

India is heritage. London is home — where the small-dog culture is close even though I don't have one of my own.

Both true. Both anchored. Both load-bearing.



Heritage and home.

The UK has built standards over decades. FEDIAF discipline, transparency conventions, the disclosure rigour pet parents have come to expect. That's what the category looks like grown up.

India's pet category is at a different stage — growing fast (premium and super-premium segments up more than 20% annually) but fragmented, with standards and transparency conventions still being established. Indian pet parents read the same forums and hold the same expectations as UK and US parents. They shouldn't have to wait decades for the benchmark to catch up. The benchmark already exists.

India has built plant intelligence over centuries. A culinary and medicinal lineage that has, more recently, been moving steadily into Western consumer markets — adaptogenic supplements, functional beverages, wellness foods, beauty formulations. The pet food category has barely engaged with this. TENDS draws from it directly. Ashwagandha, lotus seed, boswellia, chicory, toor dal, Bengal

gram (examples, not a complete list) brought into a contemporary pet formulation. Indian consumers recognise these from their kitchens. UK and Western consumers recognise them from their wellness shelves. The recognition runs in both directions.

Standards from where they're highest.
Ingredients from where they're oldest.

Neither market alone could have made this food. Both were needed. And only a founder with heritage in one and home in the other can integrate rather than import or export.

Here's what that architecture made possible at the design layer.

The food is built around the small-breed envelope — small per-meal volume, high per-kilogram energy demand, narrow daily window for delivery. Every ingredient has to earn the gram it takes. Bulk that doesn't deliver is cut. Density that doesn't fit is reduced.

Plant-based was a delivery decision before it was an environmental one. The Indian plant inventory — selected for amino-acid quality, protein-fibre balance, steady energy, prebiotic activity at controlled inclusion, functional contribution at the per-gram level — turns out to do that work cleaner than the default plant carbohydrates the category usually reaches for at the cost-engineering end.

Ashwagandha, lotus seed, and boswellia are not garnish. They earn their inclusion the same way the pea protein and the quinoa do.

We oven-bake the food once, in a dedicated capability we built rather than extending an existing pipeline, because lower-process retention keeps more of what was originally there. We made one food, complete and balanced for the small adult body, rather than a six-variant portfolio that the small-breed envelope wasn't asking for.

Heritage one side. Home the other.

The food carries both, structurally, not decoratively. Mumbai is where TENDS becomes visible first — a city carrying a small-dog culture parallel to London's in the ways that matter, and ready for the brand at this moment. London is where the rest of the story continues. Built across both. Launching in Mumbai.

— Chan Patel
Founder, TENDS

A Clinical Cut

For vet press, veterinary nutritionists, and clinical academic readers.

Small-dog nutritional architecture is a different envelope. Not different biology. Different constraints, amplified. The numerical underwriting matters here, because peer audiences read it differently than retail audiences do.

Per-kilogram energy demand follows allometric scaling: a 2 kg adult dog runs roughly forty per cent higher energy demand per kilogram than a 7 kg adult dog of similar age, regardless of breed. Gastric capacity follows body mass in absolute terms, not relative. The per-meal volume is materially smaller. The intake window is tighter. The per-bite payload is load-bearing in a way it isn't for a 25 kg dog.

Colonic transit sharpens it further. Miniature Poodle large-intestinal transit clusters around nine hours; Giant Schnauzer around thirty-nine. A four-fold difference in residence time at the lower end of the alimentary tract. Faecal consistency tracks accordingly. Against category assumption, fermentation tolerance runs in favour of small breeds.

The composite envelope has a clean shape: higher per-kg energy density requirement, smaller per-meal volume, faster transit, broader fermentation tolerance, and a lean-mass-and-coat-and-skin biology that reads downstream effects of marginal nutritional inputs faster than larger breeds do. Small dogs aren't fragile. They're tighter envelopes that read inputs faster.

Most commercial food for small dogs was not designed with that envelope as its design input. Small-breed formulas meet AAFCO and FEDIAF maintenance standards — the panel on the back is honest. What the regulated floor measures is whether a population-average dog will not develop nutrient deficiency over the regulatory observation window. It does not measure whether the diet is designed for a small dog's specific allometric envelope, or how it performs longitudinally against the markers small-dog owners track in the household over a fifteen-year life — coat, energy, stool consistency, dental burden.

Other brands noticed small dogs. None started with them. They arrived there, usually by scaling something down — a recipe, a process, a portfolio. Smaller portions. Smaller bag. Breed-name on the front. The fundamental design unit held constant.

Scaling down isn't a solution. It's a shortcut.

The shortcut is rational at the manufacturing level — extending an existing extrusion line and ingredient pipeline to small-breed packaging is cheaper than building a small-breed-specific pipeline from the formulation floor up. It is also visible in the product. Shared-pipeline small-breed kibble carries shared-pipeline ingredient inclusion levels, shared-pipeline processing temperatures, and shared-pipeline density choices — calibrated to the average-medium dog the line was designed around.

The small-breed envelope is a real design constraint with a substantial peer-reviewed evidence base. The category has historically answered it at the marketing layer rather than the formulation layer. The recommendation chain — vet to owner to product — is where small-breed nutritional design either becomes part of mainstream practice or stays in marketing. The clinical conversation about it has been quiet. We think it's overdue.

TENDS designed from the envelope inward. One complete-and-balanced adult formulation, plant-based on the per-gram-delivery argument the Axelsson 2013 genomic-omnivory work makes legible. Oven-baked once, in a dedicated production capability built for the food rather than extended for it. The Indian plant lineage — ashwagandha, lotus seed, boswellia, chicory, toor dal, Bengal gram — sits inside the formulation as functional ingredient and per-gram-delivery contributor, not as exotic overlay.

TENDS is wellness, not clinical. Where parent voice surfaces prescription-tier need — Cavalier MVD, brachycephalic dermatology, diet-as-adjunct-to-therapy — the brand defers to vet judgment and stays inside the wellness frame. We're at the start of doing the longitudinal observational work any small-breed-specific design discipline needs over time. We're actively interested in clinical conversation about it.

— Chan Patel
Founder, TENDS

A Story Cut

For lifestyle press, profile writers, and content creators.

I don't have a dog. Not yet.

It's an unusual sentence to read at the start of a small-dog-food brand's essay. It's also the most honest place to start.

The decade I spent looking at the category from outside — reading pet parents through their forum conversations, watching what they were asking for, what wasn't there — taught me to be careful about brand stories that lean too quickly on the founder's own pet. Pet food has a good founder-story tradition; most of those stories are sincere, and I have respect for the founders telling them. TENDS doesn't have one of those, and we're being deliberate about not pretending it does. The small-dog culture is a shared one. You don't need to be inside it to see what it's asking for.

You can read the gap at the bowl long before the lab measures it. The dog who picks. The morning bile. The coat that dulls instead of shines. The post-meal exhaustion you'd been calling personality. The tear stains, the tiny stomach, the appetite that reads as fussy and is actually a system running out of room. Some of what looks like a small dog being a small dog is a small dog telling you the math hasn't worked yet.

There are households I've sat in where the food question runs underneath everything else for years. A new bag every six months because the last one stopped working. A topper, then another topper, then a third. A shelf in the kitchen that turned into a small pharmacy without anyone deciding it should. Conversations on Sunday with the vet, on Monday with the breeder, on Wednesday at midnight on a forum, all arriving at slightly different versions of try this. The dog meanwhile is doing what dogs do — adapting quietly to a margin that's just slightly thinner than it should be.

The small-dog destination forums know this. Places where the same handful of parents have been comparing notes for a decade or more — Poodle, Yorkie, Cavalier, Pug — have arrived at a vocabulary the category has not. They distinguish adequate from thriving. They watch stool, coat, energy in slow patterns. They are doing the longitudinal work the category isn't doing for them. What the category sells as a small-breed answer is, for them, an opening offer the dog will eventually correct against. Two years in, they're back at the forum, asking again.

The cute small-dog register — the personality-name bag, the kibble shaped like a paw print, the cheerful copy that talks at the dog rather than the parent feeding her — used to be enough. It isn't, not in the homes I've watched. The parents most invested in their small dogs are reading ingredient panels the way they read their own. They're checking provenance. They're noticing the gap between marketing-layer claim and design-layer evidence. Small dogs are the largest urban-dog population. The audience holding the leash is the most discerning the category has ever had. The food that was good enough for fifteen years isn't.

What that opens up isn't a product story. It's a register story — about a category that grew up with one kind of customer and is having to grow up again, with another. TENDS is one entry in that. There will be others. The interesting question is what the audience is asking for, and whether the category is going to answer at the design layer or keep answering at the marketing layer.

We chose to build slowly. One food, one hydration system, a small treat range, one topical line. Each piece does its own work and fits the same daily envelope. The brand sits next to the dog and the household without trying to compete with either for attention.

The dog is the dog. The household is the household. The food sits inside both, quietly, and does its work.

— Chan Patel
Founder, TENDS

Design First. Footprint Followed. A Sustainability Cut.

For sustainability press, climate-conscious consumer press, and B Corp-adjacent surfaces.

TENDS wasn't built from a sustainability brief. It was built from a small-dog design problem. The footprint followed.

That sequence matters. It isn't the order I'd have predicted at the start of the work, and it isn't the order most sustainability-led brand storytelling reports. Most brands begin from a sustainability promise — to the audience, to the regulator, to themselves — and design backward into a product that supports the promise. We did the opposite without intending to. The small-dog envelope was binding enough on its own that solving for it produced a different kind of product. A smaller material footprint, a smaller water footprint, a smaller energy footprint fell out of the design work.

We set out to feed small dogs properly. Not to save the planet.

We say it that way because it's true, and because the alternative is to perform a virtue we didn't begin from. Virtue-led brand storytelling is increasingly a register the audience can read and tire of. What lands instead, in our experience, is the structural account: this is what the design problem was, this is the solution we built, this is the footprint that fell out of the solution. The footprint is real. The story underneath it is honest about where it came from.

So — what fell out.

Less materials. The pet food category has been moving toward more for fifteen years — more SKUs, more life-stage variants, more flavour extensions, more breed-specific lines. Each variant is a separate manufacturing run, a separate packaging line, a separate supply-chain extension. We made the structural decision not to contribute to that compounding. One food, properly built for the small adult body. No second version to fix the first. No variant to cover what the original missed. Fewer products, properly built, is less of almost everything that gets measured downstream of pet food production. The household-level version is also lighter: fewer bags, less small-pharmacy compounding over the years a dog is in the house.

Less water. Most wet and fresh pet foods are sixty to seventy per cent water. That water is packaged, refrigerated, transported, and unloaded — to arrive somewhere water already exists. For small dogs the issue is sharper: per-meal volume is already tight, and water carried in the food displaces space that could otherwise carry nutrients. We keep them separate. Dense nutrition in the food. Hydration formulated to work alongside it. The water footprint of that decision follows from the nutritional design, not from a packaging brief.

Less energy. Most commercial dog food relies on heavy processing — high heat, multiple steps, ingredients reworked into final form, supplements added back to compensate for what the process strips. Energy goes into making the food, energy goes into compensating for the making. We oven-bake real ingredients once, in a dedicated capability built for this food. The decision was made for bioavailability. It reads downstream as a smaller energy footprint.

The relationship between the design and the footprint is not coincidental. It isn't the result of a sustainability optimisation laid over the product. It's the result of taking the small-dog envelope seriously. When you build for the dog rather than for the portfolio, the portfolio gets smaller. When you build for delivery rather than for water-as-bulk, the water gets less. When you build for retention rather than for high-heat processing, the energy gets less.

The interesting question for category sustainability writing isn't whether brands can layer sustainability claims onto products designed without sustainability in mind — the category does that already. The interesting question is what happens when the design itself produces the smaller footprint, without anyone marketing the design as a sustainability move.

Less, by design. More, by science.

— Chan Patel
Founder, TENDS